



Foundations of Oriental Medicine Content Outline

Effective September 1, 2026

Note to Candidate: This document serves as a guide to assist in examination preparation for candidates who have met NCBAHM™ eligibility requirements. Below is the content outline for the Foundations of Oriental Medicine examination.

Domain I. Patient Assessment Methods (28% of Exam)

- A. Observation / Looking (*Wang*) (6%)
 - 1. Identify the manifestation of Spirit (Shen) (e.g., complexion, general behavior).
 - 2. Assess the appearance of the eyes, nose, ears, mouth, lips, throat, face (e.g., color, moisture, texture, corresponding organ locations).
 - 3. Identify manifestations of the tongue (e.g., body, coating, sublingual veins).
 - 4. Assess the appearance of the body (e.g., shape, movement, head, hair, neck, back, chest, abdomen, extremities, blood vessels, skin, nails).
 - 5. Assess the appearance of excretions (e.g., mucus, saliva, sweat, discharge, stool, urine, blood).
- B. Auscultation and Olfaction / Listening and Smelling (*Wen*) (3%)
 - 1. Assess respiratory sounds, voice, tonal qualities, and speech.
 - 2. Identify odors of the body, breath, excretions, secretions (e.g., urine, stool, vaginal discharge, sweat, wound exudates).
- C. Inquiry / Asking (*Wen*) (10%)
 - 1. Identify presenting complaints (e.g., onset, location, aggravation).
 - 2. Formulate additional questions based on patient's responses and examination findings.
 - 3. Conduct a Review of Systems (ROS) utilizing "Ten Questions" (*Shi Wen*) (e.g., pain, energy level, sweating, body sensations) and other approaches.
 - 4. Identify etiological factors, including internal (e.g., emotions), external (e.g., environment) and miscellaneous (e.g., diet, occupation) factors.



5. Assess personal and family health history (e.g., past diagnoses, concurrent treatments).

D. Palpation / Touching (*Qie*) (9%)

1. Differentiate characteristics of the radial pulses (e.g., rate, depth, strength).
2. Identify findings from palpation of other body areas (e.g., abdomen, torso, limbs) and channels (e.g., temperature, texture, pain, tissue quality, edema).

Domain II. Pathomechanisms and Pattern Differentiation (38% of Exam)

1. Analyze assessment findings to establish pattern differentiation and underlying pathomechanism(s) based on the following theories:
 - a. *Yin/Yang*
 - b. *Five Elements (Wu Xing)*
 - c. *Eight Principles (Ba Gang)* (e.g., interior, exterior, heat, cold)
 - d. *Qi, Blood, Body Fluids (Qi, Xue, Jin Ye)*
 - e. *Channel (Jing Luo)* (e.g., 12 primary channels, eight extraordinary channels, Luo-connecting channels)
 - f. *Organ (Zang Fu)*
 - g. *Six Stages* (e.g., *Tai Yang*, *Yang Ming*, *Jue Yin*)
 - h. *Four Levels (Wei, Qi, Ying, Xue)*
 - i. *Triple Burner (San Jiao)*
 - j. *Internal etiology* (e.g., seven emotions, stress)
 - k. *External etiology* (e.g., wind, damp, cold, dryness, heat, summer heat, pestilential Qi (Li Qi))
 - l. *Miscellaneous etiology* (e.g., diet, lifestyle, trauma)
 - m. *Chinese organ clock*

Domain III. Treatment Planning (34% of Exam)

1. Formulate appropriate treatment principles based upon the following theories:
 - a. *Yin/Yang*
 - b. *Five Elements (Wu Xing)*

- c. *Eight Principles (Ba Gang)* (e.g., interior/exterior, heat/cold)
 - d. *Qi, Blood, Body Fluids (Qi, Xue, Jin Ye)*
 - e. *Channel (Jing Luo)* (e.g., 12 primary channels, extraordinary channels, Luo-connecting channels)
 - f. *Organ (Zang Fu)*
 - g. *Six Stages* (e.g., *Tai Yang, Yang Ming, Jue Yin*)
 - h. *Four Levels (Wei, Qi, Ying, Xue)*
 - i. *Triple Burner (San Jiao)*
 - j. *Internal etiology* (e.g., seven emotions, stress)
 - k. *External etiology* (e.g., wind, damp, cold, dryness, heat, summer heat, pestilential Qi (Li Qi))
 - l. *Miscellaneous etiology* (e.g., diet, lifestyle, trauma)
2. Establish treatment priorities (e.g., Root and Branch [*Ben Biao*], acute vs. chronic) and develop a treatment plan.
 3. Modify the treatment plan based on patient's response, disease progression, and lifestyle factors.
 4. Explain assessment findings and the treatment plan to the patient.
 5. Counsel the patient on self-care home management techniques to prevent disease and maintain health (e.g., *Qi Gong, Tai Ji*, breathing techniques).
 6. Provide dietary recommendations according to Chinese medicine (e.g., temperature, taste, functions).



Foundations of Oriental Medicine Examination Suggested Bibliography

The Content Outline is the primary resource for studying for this examination. The purpose of this Bibliography is only to provide the candidate with suggested resources to utilize in preparation for the examination. Candidates should feel free to consider other resources that cover the material in the Content Outline.

There is no single text recommended by NCBAHM™. All NCBAHM™ examination modules reflect practice in the United States as determined by the most recent job analysis.

NCBAHM™'s item writers and examination development committee members frequently use the following texts as resources; however, the sources used are not limited to the books listed here. The NCBAHM™ does not endorse any third-party study/preparation guide.

Cheng, Xinnong. (Ed.). *Chinese Acupuncture and Moxibustion*. 4th ed. Beijing: Foreign Languages Press, 2019.

Deng, Tietao. *Practical Diagnosis in Traditional Chinese Medicine*. London: Churchill Livingstone, 1999.

Kastner, Joerg. *Chinese Nutritional Therapy: Dietetics in Traditional Chinese Medicine*. 3rd ed. New York: Thieme, 2021.

Maciocia, Giovanni. *Diagnosis in Chinese Medicine: A Comprehensive Guide*. 2nd ed. Philadelphia: Elsevier Churchill Livingstone, 2018.

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Maclean, William, Jane Lyttleton, Mark Bayley, and Kathryn Taylor. *Clinical Handbook of Internal Medicine, The Treatment of Disease with Traditional Chinese Medicine*. 2nd ed. Seattle: Eastland Press, 2018.

Scheid, Volker, Dan Bensky, Andrew Ellis, and Randall Barolet. *Chinese Herbal Medicine: Formulas and Strategies*. Portable 2nd ed. Seattle, WA: Eastland Press, 2015.

Wiseman, Nigel, and Andy Ellis. *Fundamentals of Chinese Medicine*. Revised Edition. Brookline, MA: Paradigm Publications, 1995.

Wu, Yan, and Warren Fischer. *Practical Therapeutics of Traditional Chinese Medicine*. Ed. Jake P. Fratkin. Brookline, MA: Paradigm Publications, 1997.